throw their last die and engage in their final battle; for, let it terminate how it might, there would not remain for them musket ammunition enough to try the fortune of another. It was necessary, therefore, that their victory should not only be sure, but complete; so complete as to open for them a free passage to the head of the Khyber – and perhaps beyond it.'[1]

That evening, a simple strategy was thrashed out. The wounded soldiers and the camp followers with their home-made pikes would man the defences, while every last able-bodied soldier would be divided into one of three columns. The columns would all 'march direct upon Akbar's camp, burn it, drive him into the river, and bring off his guns'.[2] There was no alternative plan in case of failure.

The following day, in the chilly pre-dawn glimmer of 7 April, the city gates were thrown open, and for the first time since they arrived in late December the entire garrison marched out. Sale had expected to surprise the defenders, but word of the General's gamble had somehow leaked out and, as the sun rose over the mountains to the east of Jalalabad, the troops saw that Akbar Khan, far from being taken by surprise, had formed his entire army into battle order 'and they were turning out in their thousands'.[3]

Firing began immediately. The first casualties were inflicted on the westernmost column, which was commanded by the long-bearded Baptist teetotaller Henry Havelock. Akbar launched all his cavalry at Havelock. As 'large masses of horse' closed in, Havelock coolly ordered the column into a square and repulsed the attack, inflicting heavy losses on the circling horsemen. 'I felt throughout that Lord Jesus was at my side,' wrote Havelock later. Havelock's men had become rather bored of his sermons during the siege; they were, however, deeply impressed by their commander's almost mystical sangfroid in battle. 'He was as calm under fire as if he stood in a drawing room full of ladies,' one wrote afterwards.[4]

Throughout the battle, the column was skilfully supported by the artillery from the city walls. This was something the Kabul defenders had never properly achieved but here, as in earlier battles during the campaign, accurate and effective cannonfire made a crucial difference against armies of Afghan tribesmen unused to grapeshot and modern explosive shells. Moreover the flat plains of Jalalabad favoured the British style of disciplined infantry warfare and did not allow the Afghans to bring into play the mountain guerrilla tactics that had proved so devastating in the